THE AFGHAN, THE HINDU, AND THE TIMURID

Humayun set off to reconquer Hindustan in a remarkably cavalier manner at the end of 1554. With only 3,000 men and his twelve-year-old heir, he boarded a raft made of timber at Jalalabad and ‘pleasantly floated down the river to Pyshavir’. The harem had been left in Kabul, which was under the governorship of Munim Khan, with only Maham Anaga accompanying Akbar to Hindustan. After they had crossed the Indus, Humayun had Akbar bathed and brought before him and, under a crescent moon, he read some verses of the Koran and, at the end of each verse, breathed on the prince ‘and was so delighted and happy, it might be said that he had then acquired all the good fortune of this world, and the blessings of the next’. Humayun was forty-six years old at this time, a slim, elegant man with a narrow face and a short, pointed beard. He would have been wearing his distinctive high turban, a long qaba (kurta-like gown), as was the fashion, with a sleeveless overcoat and furs. This moment with his father may have been one of the last abiding memories Akbar would have of Humayun. The Padshah so happy in the gathering dawn, the holy verses, and the gentle breath, with Akbar himself a conduit for Humayun’s blessings. ‘Alas that the Emperor Humayun died so early, and that I had no opportunity of showing him faithful service!’ he said to Abu’l Fazl many decades later.

The retaking of Hindustan by Humayun was easy for a number of reasons. His own brothers were no longer a threat. The Afghan forces were dispersed and fragmented. Timur’s long-ago invasion had fractured the cohesion of the Delhi Sultanate, seeding small chiefdoms headed by erstwhile Tughlaq governors in provinces far from Delhi. Sher Shah Sur’s dynasty had been an unforeseen blaze of stability, but it had crumbled equally spectacularly following the rapid collapse of five successive Sur pretenders, bringing political chaos to the region around Delhi. Given all this, Humayun, greatly aided by his general Bairam Khan, who brought a further 5,000 troops from Kandahar, was able to regain his lands remarkably easily. The Punjab was captured and so was the great city of Lahore. Sikandar Shah’s forces were twice defeated, and on 23 July 1555, Humayun entered Delhi.